



THE CLEAN STACK GUIDE

The No-BS Supplement Checklist for Black Men.

5 label red flags • The 5 essentials • What to skip • The store checklist

From @melaninfitmen

Melanin Fit Men | Health & Fitness

FREE RESOURCE — NOT FOR RESALE. This guide is for educational purposes and is not medical advice. Consult a physician before starting any supplement, especially if you take prescription medication.

WHY THIS GUIDE EXISTS

I've spent 15 years inside the supplement manufacturing industry. I've seen how the sausage gets made — what goes into the bottle, what the label hides, and how products get designed to sell instead of to work.

Here's the truth nobody at the supplement counter will tell you: the FDA does not approve supplements before they hit the shelf. The label is your only line of defense — and most labels are written to beat you, not inform you.

And for Black men, the stakes are higher:

- **76% of Black Americans are Vitamin D deficient** — melanin reduces Vitamin D synthesis from sunlight, and almost nobody is telling us.
- **56% of Black men have high blood pressure** — the highest rate of any group in the world, which makes minerals like magnesium worth understanding.
- **Heart disease is our #1 killer** — so the quality of your omega-3 isn't a detail. It's the whole point.

Most supplements are overpriced, underdosed, and dressed up in marketing. But the right supplements, at the right doses, in the right forms, from brands that prove what's in the bottle — those can genuinely support your health.

This guide is the insider filter. Five label rules that expose the games. Five essentials that earn their spot. The junk to skip. And a checklist you can pull up in any store aisle.

READ THE LABEL, KING. THIS GUIDE TEACHES YOU HOW.

THE 5 LABEL RULES

Every trick in the industry shows up on the label — if you know where to look. Run every product through these five rules before your money leaves your pocket.

RULE 1 — NO PROPRIETARY BLENDS. EVER.

A "proprietary blend" lists ingredients without exact doses. That's not protecting a secret formula — it's hiding that the expensive ingredients are in there at doses too small to matter. If you can't see exact amounts, you can't trust it. Walk away.

RULE 2 — WATCH FOR FAIRY DUSTING

A label with 30 impressive ingredients usually means 30 useless doses. Brands sprinkle in a pinch of a trendy ingredient just to print it on the front of the bottle. Fewer ingredients at full clinical doses beats a kitchen-sink formula every time.

RULE 3 — THE FORM IS THE PRODUCT

Two bottles can say "Magnesium 400mg" and be completely different products. Magnesium **oxide** is poorly absorbed — it's in the bottle because it's cheap. Magnesium **glycinate** is what you actually want. Same story with fish oil (triglyceride form beats ethyl ester) and zinc (picolinate beats oxide). The form tells you if the brand cut corners.

RULE 4 — DEMAND THIRD-PARTY TESTING

Anyone can print "lab tested" on a label — that phrase is legally meaningless. Look for independent certification seals: **NSF Certified for Sport, Informed Choice, or USP Verified**. These mean an outside lab confirmed what's in the bottle matches the label.

RULE 5 — MEGADOSES ARE MARKETING, NOT MEDICINE

"50,000% Daily Value!" is a red flag, not a feature. More is not better — zinc over 40mg a day depletes copper, and megadosed cheap B-vitamins mostly produce expensive urine. Clinical doses, not circus numbers.

THE 5 ESSENTIALS FOR BLACK MEN

If you take nothing else from this guide: these five, at these doses, in these forms, cover the gaps that hit Black men hardest. This is the clean stack.

01

Vitamin D3

The non-negotiable

THE DOSE

4,000–5,000 IU daily.

WHEN TO TAKE IT

With your biggest meal — D3 is fat-soluble and needs dietary fat to absorb.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR US

76% of Black Americans are deficient. Melanin reduces Vitamin D synthesis from sunlight, so we need more than the standard advice assumes. Supports bone health, immune function, and mood.

WHAT TO BUY

D3 (cholecalciferol), softgel in an oil base. Pair with Vitamin K2 if you can find a clean combo.

RED FLAG TO AVOID

D2 (ergocalciferol) — the cheaper, weaker form. And dry tablets with no fat source.

02

Magnesium Glycinate

The sleep and pressure mineral

THE DOSE

200–400mg daily (elemental magnesium).

WHEN TO TAKE IT

30–60 minutes before bed. The glycinate form is calming, not stimulating.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR US

With 56% of Black men dealing with high blood pressure, magnesium is a mineral we cannot afford to be low on. Supports healthy blood pressure, sleep quality, and muscle recovery.

WHAT TO BUY

Magnesium glycinate (also sold as bisglycinate). Check the ELEMENTAL magnesium number on the label.

RED FLAG TO AVOID

Magnesium oxide — poorly absorbed, mostly a laxative. It's in the bottle because it costs pennies.

03

Omega-3 Fish Oil

The heart defender

THE DOSE

2,000–3,000mg combined EPA + DHA daily (read the EPA/DHA line, not the "fish oil" line).

WHEN TO TAKE IT

With meals, split morning and evening if it repeats on you.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR US

Heart disease is the #1 killer of Black men. Omega-3s are anti-inflammatory and support heart and prostate health — this is the one to never cheap out on.

WHAT TO BUY

Triglyceride-form fish oil, third-party tested for purity. Dark bottle, refrigerate after opening.

RED FLAG TO AVOID

Ethyl ester form hidden behind a big "1,000mg Fish Oil!" front label that's only 300mg EPA+DHA.

04

Creatine Monohydrate

The most proven supplement in history

THE DOSE

5g daily. No loading phase needed. Consistency is the whole game.

WHEN TO TAKE IT

Any time of day — timing doesn't matter, the daily habit does.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR US

Decades of research. Supports muscle, strength, brain function, and cardiovascular health. For men training after 35, it's the closest thing to a sure bet on the shelf.

WHAT TO BUY

Plain creatine monohydrate powder — Creapure if you want the gold standard. One ingredient on the label.

RED FLAG TO AVOID

"Advanced" creatine blends (HCL, esters, liquid creatine) — more money for less evidence.

05

Zinc Picolinate

The testosterone and immune mineral

THE DOSE

15–30mg daily. DO NOT exceed 40mg — excess zinc depletes copper.

WHEN TO TAKE IT

With food to avoid nausea. Away from your magnesium dose if possible.

WHY IT MATTERS FOR US

Supports immune function, prostate health, and healthy testosterone levels — three things every man over 35 should be paying attention to.

WHAT TO BUY

Zinc picolinate. If you take it long-term, choose a version with 1–2mg copper.

RED FLAG TO AVOID

Megadosed 50mg+ zinc products, and zinc oxide — the sunscreen ingredient, barely absorbed.

SKIP THESE — THE MONEY BURNERS

The industry makes its margin on hope. These categories are where your money goes to die:

"TEST BOOSTERS"

Herb blends with heroic names and proprietary doses. If your testosterone is genuinely low, that's a conversation with your doctor and a blood panel — not a \$60 bottle. Sleep, lifting, zinc, and body composition move the needle more than any booster on the shelf.

FAT BURNERS

Mostly caffeine in a costume. The "thermogenic matrix" is a proprietary blend (Rule 1) wrapped around stimulants. A calorie deficit and your 4-day training split do the job for free.

BCAAs (IF YOU EAT ENOUGH PROTEIN)

If you're hitting your protein target from food or a quality protein powder, BCAAs add nothing — you already ate them. They're amino acids sold twice.

GREENS POWDERS AS A VEGETABLE REPLACEMENT

A scoop of dried powder is not a plate of vegetables — the fiber is gone and the doses are fairy-dusted (Rule 2). Fine as insurance on travel weeks; a scam as a lifestyle.

DETOX AND CLEANSE PRODUCTS

You have a liver and two kidneys. They are the detox. Anything promising to "flush toxins" is selling you your own biology back at \$40 a bottle.

EVERY DOLLAR YOU DON'T BURN HERE FUNDS THE STACK THAT WORKS.

THE CLEAN STACK CHECKLIST

Pull this up in the aisle or before you hit "add to cart." A clean product passes ALL of these:

- **Exact doses listed** — zero proprietary blends anywhere on the label
- **Clinical doses** — matches the numbers in this guide, not a sprinkle
- **The right form** — glycinate, picolinate, triglyceride, monohydrate
- **Third-party seal** — NSF, Informed Choice, or USP on the bottle
- **Short ingredient list** — the fewer the ingredients, the fewer the hiding places
- **No miracle language** — "melts fat," "boosts T by 300%" = put it back
- **Lot number + expiration date** — basic accountability from a real facility

The Stack at a Glance

Supplement	Daily Dose	Best Time	Form to Buy
Vitamin D3	4,000–5,000 IU	With biggest meal	D3 softgel (oil base)
Magnesium	200–400mg	Before bed	Glycinate
Omega-3	2,000–3,000mg EPA+DHA	With meals	Triglyceride form
Creatine	5g	Any time, daily	Plain monohydrate
Zinc	15–30mg	With food	Picolinate

Start one supplement at a time, a week apart, so you know what's doing what. If you take prescription medication — especially for blood pressure — clear the stack with your doctor first.



READ THE LABEL, KING.

You now know more about reading a supplement label than 95% of the men in any gym. Use it. Teach it.
And never buy a proprietary blend again.

KEEP LEVELING UP

The King's Drop — supplement truth in your inbox, one email a week, no fluff. You're already in if this guide came from melaninfitmen.com.

Comment **FUEL** on any @melaninfitmen post for the 5-Meal Prep Blueprint.

Comment **KING** for the Black Men's Health Starter Guide — all five pillars in one.

Watch the breakdowns on YouTube: @MelaninFitMen

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Consult a physician before beginning any supplement regimen.

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